Data C104 Midterm 2 at a glance

Weeks 5–9 | 2 short answers (10 pts, 30 min) + scenario essay (20 pts, 60 min)

SUMMARY: seven claims

- Institutions make social order by **making people legible**.
- Privacy → **contextual integrity** → **oblivion**.
- Surveillance **disciplines**: panopticon, now bulk and cheap.
- **Numbers as persuasion**. **Prediction** is the new paradigm of governance.
- History is **neoliberalism**: risk moved from collective pools to **actuarial fairness**.
- **Fairness** turned a social question into engineering. **Co-production**.
- **Futures** are narratives (templates), performative.
- **Silicon Valley** = capital, military, hidden labor. Built by **universities, military spending, culture/legal climate**.

PRIVACY (Wk 5)

Old: privacy as *individual control over personal info*; not applicable in the datafied world. Thin: self-regulation, **FIPs**, **PII**. ToS / privacy policy (burden falls on user).
Cases: **Netflix Prize** (de-identification fails), **Crisis Text Line** (consented data → train AI), Havasupai, TSA scanners.

- **Malkin Contextual integrity**: privacy = *appropriate info flow*, judged by context / norms / expectations. 5 parameters: type, subject, sender, recipient, transmission principle.
  × predicts feelings, favors existing norms (salary secrecy).
- **Pressly Oblivion**: privacy = *prevents info from being created* in the first place. Ideology of information. Neoliberal critique: privacy becomes *property*. Privacy ≠ secrecy.

SURVEILLANCE, NUMBERS, DECISIONS (Wk 6)

Institutions make social order via 1) surveillance 2) numbers 3) decision-making power on people, and nudge them.
Narrative templates: 1) **1984** → control 2) **panopticon** → discipline 3) **global analytics** → security.

- **Targeted precision** vs mass surveillance; **differential exposure**. NSA / Snowden, NYPD DAS, gang database.
- Numbers look fair, objective; **performativity** (US News rankings).
- **Libertarian paternalism**: free to choose, but designer arranges options. Choice architecture, nudges, Facebook turnout.
- **Foucault Panopticon**: power *visible but unverifiable*; you become *the principle of your own subjection*. Visibility is a trap.
- **Porter Objectivity & Authority**: objectivity = *impersonality* + *fairness* (numbers give both). **Weapon of the weak**, technology of distance. Standardize methods = standardize values.

AUTOMATED DECISION-MAKING (Wk 7)

Algorithms → fair? → accurate? × feedback loops, stigma, institutional goals, agency.
ADM is a **panoptic sort**, a form of **governance**; fairness co-produced with insurance and **neoliberalism**.

- **Risk scores**: **proxy**, what data *represents* (health costs → sick Black patients; facial classifiers worse on dark skin). COMPAS: calibration vs error rates.
- **Prediction** (Ofqual A-levels): × due process, stigma, circulation & durability, **performativity** (self-fulfilling prophecy), agency.
- **Cybernetic choice architecture** (Google Maps). Collective vs **individualized risk**: welfare state → actuarial fairness (unisex insurance).
- **Eubanks Allegheny algorithm**, AFST child welfare: *profiles the poor* (who's in the model?), feedback loop, × privacy / due process = price of services.
- **Fourcade & Healy Data double** (credit scores): your data decides *life chances*. **Classification situation**, nominal vs ordinal, **eigencapital** (embodied, objectified, institutionalized); visibility & invisibility both bad (lumpenscoretariat).

FUTURES / AI NARRATIVES / AUTOMATION (Wk 8)

Talking about the future is never neutral: it shapes what is built, funded, feared, regulated. Reusable **templates** (performativity).
AI framed by sci-fi & **transhumanism**: 1) doomsday / existential risk 2) longevity 3) abundance.
Automation = **social relation** between workers and owners → abundance *or* unemployment / inequality. Design is a **choice** (Winner).
Purpose of futuring: 1) impose order / control 2) open imagination / build common ground.
Tech as capital, deskilling, Taylorism, productivity.

- **Hildebrandt Diana's onlife day**. Law: can be violated, can be contested. Design: cannot be violated, invisible (cookies).
- **Le Guin Carrier bag**: fiction sensitizes; hero-spear vs bag.
- **Andreessen** techno-optimist: growth, techno-capital machine (the opposite story).
- **Noble Machine design**: 1) record-playback (retains human skill) 2) numerical control (skill moves to office). N/C won: Air Force + management control. Deskilling mostly fails (machines unreliable). × technological determinism.

SILICON VALLEY (Wk 9)

Produces wealth & social order; a **story** (materials, tech, founders); underneath: **networks, military, capital**. Winners of each wave ride the next (chips → PCs → internet → platforms → AI).

- **Nicholas** three reasons: 1) **universities** (Stanford startup culture vs MIT) 2) **military spending** (early adopter of chips; Lockheed Santa Clara's largest employer; now YC funds missile startups) 3) **culture & legal climate** (California free-market libertarianism, no non-competes, demand for VC).
- **Vinsel & Russell Innovation is overvalued** (creative destruction / disruption). Tech > innovation; most work is **maintenance**.
- **Fang War**: defense VC, Cold War roots, China AI arms race. **Democracy paradox**: defending it with deportation surveillance and wars?
- **Crawford Labor**: workplace AI → surveillance, **time discipline**, deskilling, tracked micro; humans treated like robots.
- **Sloane Business of AI**: sells **prediction as asset** (value speculative). × data is infinite (like oil) × everything can be automated (status decides) × prediction replaces judgment (**discretion** lost: Boolean vs semantic search adds work / bias).

HCE TOOLS → EVIDENCE

- **Power**: panopticon, Amazon rate, choice architecture
- **Sociotechnical systems**: AFST, COMPAS in courts, Diana's onlife world
- **Classification**: risk labels, AFST
- **Representation**: story of the Valley, data double, proxies as ground truth
- **Performativity**: AFST, US News ranking, predictions of the future
- **Narratives**: AI narratives, futures
- **Agency**: nudges, choice architecture
- **Identity**: data double, eigencapital
- **Vulnerability**: crisis hotline, poverty profiling
- **Labor**: deskilling
- **Co-production**: privacy laws, objectivity, fairness, insurance, neoliberalism, VC & Valley

WEEKS 1–4 TO CARRY IN

Winner: tech is inherently political. **Bowker & Star**: classification (apartheid race). **Hacking**: classification, performativity. **Scott**: state legibility. **Kuhn / Collins & Pinch**: local knowledge. **Biopower**: statistics with eugenics.

ANALYTICAL ESSAY

Name the tension (efficiency / scale vs _____).

1. Who is made legible? Who is invisible?
2. What does the prediction do? Performativity, agency, fairness, risk.
3. Who owns / makes decisions? Choice architecture, deskilling, tech as capital.
4. (Story?) Narrative: who tells it and who it leaves out.

Recommendation.

Modules: design is regulation · consent is not enough · AFST best case still profiles · two ways to automate · status decides automation · panoptic sort (data double / eigencapital) · weak elites use numbers · narrative future prediction · democracy paradox · time discipline (we are all tech workers)